in favor of

Rebuttal to Argument ~~for~~ Measure V

We all want a safe, vibrant Berkeley with excellent firefighters, reliable 911 service, wildfire protection, and well-maintained public facilities. We also want a city that residents and small businesses can afford.

Berkeley already has an annual budget approaching $1 billion. Yet during budget deliberations, the City Council threatened to close a fire station and eliminate 6 firefighters and 21 police officers and dispatchers — chopping essential services while shielding favored projects.

Now they're invoking public safety to justify another tax. Sound fiscal management would prioritize fundamental emergency preparedness and resilience services within the substantial revenue taxpayers already provide.

Measure V does not guarantee that revenues will fund proponents' highlighted projects. By law, the current or future City Councils could spend the funds on anything they like. **It is a regressive sales tax, making purchases more expensive and falling disproportionately on students, service workers, and lower-income households. Amid unprecedentedly high living costs, affordability should be the City's priority.**

Our Council has run up a $30 million structural deficit. They've **tripled** this since voters granted Councilmembers "full-time" salaries—even though several maintain lucrative outside work, and under our charter, staff runs the city. Responsible leaders sacrifice from the top: Why did Council offer no ballot measure to return their salaries to half-time, offering substantial savings to preserve other City jobs?

Berkeley deserves responsible budgeting, clear priorities, and real accountability. Let's protect essential services, spend existing revenues wisely, and keep Berkeley safe, vibrant, resilient — and affordable.

Vote NO on Measure V.

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CITY OF BERKELEY
CITY CLERK DEPARTMENT

s/McKinley Crespo
Small Business Owner

s/Barbara Gilbert
Former Aide to Berkeley Mayor Shirley Dean

s/Donna DiDiemar
Neighborhood Activist and Former Small Business Owner

s/Joshua Glatt
Software Engineer and Composer

s/ Isabelle Gaston
Assistant Treasurer, Affordable Berkeley

Submitted on behalf of: Affordable Berkeley. Isabelle Gaston, Assistant Treasurer

Isabelle Gaston